them at the arms talks as second-class citizens—and if the unthinkable happened, it was possible their arsenal of giant missiles could overwhelm our older, unmodernized, and vulnerable retaliatory forces. Well-meaning or not, the nuclear freeze movement had an agenda that could have been written in Moscow.

In May 1982, I sent a letter to Brezhnev suggesting a resumption of arms control talks at Geneva before the end of June. “As you know,” I wrote,

> it is my view that our previous efforts at limiting strategic offensive arms did not adequately meet the standards of reduction, equality and verification. The awesome destructive power of nuclear weapons imposes on our two countries both the practical necessity and the moral imperative to do everything within our power to reduce and even eliminate the possibility of their use in war. This has been the thrust of my country’s approach to nuclear arms control for over the past 35 years . . . we now stand at another historic juncture in the effort to reduce the threat of nuclear war.

While Brezhnev’s response was not cordial, he agreed to new talks. “It is not our fault,” he wrote, “that the Strategic Arms Limitation process was interrupted for a long time. . . . The position with which the U.S., judging by your speech of May 9, is approaching the negotiations cannot but cause apprehension and even doubts as to the seriousness of the intentions of the U.S. side.”

While I was reading the letter, I jotted down my reactions to his comments in the margin. Next to the sentences above, my comment was: *“He has to be kidding.”*

To a remark by Brezhnev that “the ‘substantial’ reduction the U.S. side is talking about on the basis of the picture it